was tolerant of his Buddhist as well as his Hindu subjects, supporting scholars of both faiths and funding the construction of many temples and monasteries.

Islam first entered Kashmir in the sixth annual attack into India by the Afghan sultan Mahmud of Ghazni, early in the eleventh century. But Mahmud was forced to turn back by winter weather and reached only the outskirts of Srinagar. A series of feuding Hindu monarchs subsequently stripped Kashmir of much of its domain; Ladakh and Jammu broke off to become independent kingdoms by the dawn of the thirteenth century. Sufi saints then wandered into the valley, converting many Hindu peasants with their message of love. In the early part of the next century, Rinchin, a prince of Ladakh, forced to flee from Tibet, came to Kashmir with many followers and his Hindu queen, Kota Rani. She outlived her husband, was famed for her beauty and independence, and was admired throughout Kashmir as its greatest female ruler. (The most famous modern Kashmiri woman to rule all of India, however, was Jawaharlal Nehru's talented daughter Indira Gandhi.)

Many Muslim sultans of Shams-ud-din's dynasty ruled over Kashmir for 222 years, with none greater than Zain-ud-Abidin (1420–70). His genius was never to forget that Kashmiri Hindus and Buddhists were equally loyal and, if treated with toleration, would prove as helpful to his land's growth and its arts as the brilliant Sufi saints and poets of his court. His patronage of drama revived its practice throughout Kashmir, just as his generous support of local rug-makers, shawl-weavers, wood-carvers, and papier-mâché artists brought all those Kashmiri crafts to their peaks of artistic perfection, hailed the world over. Hindu pandits wrote of the Vale of Kashmir becoming a smiling garden of industry in Zain's reign.

Akbar, the "Great" Mughal, annexed Kashmir to his imperium in 1586. Akbar's son Jahangir (1606–27) loved to breathe the fragrant air of Kashmir, which he often visited with his Persian consort, Nur Mahal (Light of the World), planting their royal gardens of Shalimar and Nishat in the environs of Dal Lake. This happy valley then became, indeed, the "paradise on Earth," about which Ireland's national bard Thomas Moore was inspired to pen his popular poem *Lalla Rookh*, celebrating its beauty and attracting generations of European tourists there.

The decline and fall of the Mughal Empire in the latter part of the eighteenth century left Kashmir ripe for conquest by the Pathan plunderer Ahmad Shah Abdali, later named Durrani. Afghan invaders